Honours & Awards

National & International Recognition

- The prestigious Dr. B.C. Roy Award for community health efforts from the President of India.
- Padma Bhushan, Government of India, 2011, one of India's highest civilian honours for contributions to education and healthcare.
- Datuk Award, Government of Melaka, Malaysia, 2011.
- Golden Peacock Lifetime Achievement Award for Education & Healthcare, 2011.
- Honoured by the Government of Karnataka during the Suvarna Karnataka Year (Golden Jubilee year of formation of the state) celebrations in 2006
- Honorary Fellowship of the Faculty of General Dental Practitioners (FGDP) of the Royal College of Surgeons of England, 2004
- Phillips Medal of Ohio University, USA, in recognition of public service, 1993
- National Professor of General Practice/Family Medicine by IMA College of General Practitioners, 1992







• Antigua, whose medical graduates entered global healthcare pipelines.
• Nepal and Oman, extending Indian standards to new geographies.

Across these campuses grew a generation of global Indians shaped not in Delhi or Mumbai, but in Manipal's vision exported abroad.

This was not just expansion. It was India's soft power, decades before the term became fashionable.

The Unshakeable Bedrock — Integrity, Merit, and the War Against Favouritism

Everyone who worked with him remembers the same thing: He never compromised on merit. Not once. Not even when it cost him politically, financially, or emotionally.

A colleague recalls an incident when someone close to the administration made a request that bent the rules. Dr. Pai refused—gently, politely, but firmly. He didn't defend the decision. He didn't sermonise. He simply turned the page and moved on.

His father's mantra—no fear, no favour—had become his spine.

It explains why Manipal grew so widely yet never lost its moral centre. Why its scholarships today exceed ₹100 crore annually. Why its research ecosystem attracts global collaborators. Why 250,000 alumni across continents still call Manipal their compass.

The Healthcare Parallel — A Legacy Within a Legacy

Education was one side of the Pai inheritance. Healthcare was the other.

As hospital administrator at Kasturba Hospital in 1961, Dr. Pai quietly modernised systems long before "hospital management" became a field. Years later, he initiated Manipal Hospital in Bengaluru—a modest beginning that his son, Dr. Ranjan Pai, grew into one of India's largest healthcare networks.

Three generations. One philosophy. One mission: Heal, Educate, Elevate.

If Manipal is today synonymous with higher education and healthcare, it is because the two were never separate missions. They were twin rivers feeding a single lake—the belief that education and health together dismantle poverty.

The Leader Who Made Others Larger

Few institution-builders in India have been as comfortable stepping back from the spotlight.

In meetings, Dr. Pai asked more questions than he answered. In negotiations, he listened more than he spoke. In recognition ceremonies, he applauded louder than anyone else—usually for achievements he had quietly made possible.

One long-time faculty member summed it up best: "Working with him felt like working with someone who held open a door you never noticed was locked."

His leadership was not flashy. It was infrastructural—a soil that nourished every seed planted in it.

The 90-Year Arc — From a Barren Plateau to a Global Map

On September 17, 2025, Dr. Ramdas Pai turned 90. Ninety years is a long time to measure a life. But some lives refuse to be measured in years. They are measured in institutions, in ideas, in movements that outlive their architects.

Ask him today what he thinks of his life's work, and he will likely shrug that gentle shrug and insist that the credit belongs to his team, to his colleagues, to the town. But history will correct him. History will say he did something India had not dared to imagine.

What India Is Doing Now, He Began 30 Years Ago

As the nation charts its next 50 years—sending IITs abroad, building global alliances, crafting a new vocabulary of educational diplomacy—one truth stands out: Dr. Ramdas Pai didn't wait for the world to open its doors. He built the doors. Then he walked through them—quietly, steadily, unafraid.

In a country that often celebrates loud visionaries, he proved that revolutions can also be gentle.

And sometimes, the gentlest ones go the farthest.

At 90, Dr. Pai stands as:

- the torchbearer of India's private education revolution,
- the pioneer of internationalisation in Indian higher education,
- the architect who globalised Manipal before globalisation reached India,
- the custodian of values that shaped a quarter-million strong alumni,
- and the quiet force whose legacy touches classrooms and hospitals on multiple continents.